My AI Workforce

PRACTICAL AI GUIDE

Build a Sales Outreach Agent with n8n

⏱ 3–5 hours 📊 Intermediate–Advanced

Tools covered: n8n (self-hosted or cloud), Apollo.io or LinkedIn, Gmail

What You'll Build

A fully automated cold outreach system using n8n that: pulls prospect data from Apollo.io or LinkedIn, personalises each email using AI, sends on a schedule, tracks replies, and pauses sequences when a prospect responds — all without writing a single line of code.

Prerequisites

- n8n account (cloud: n8n.io, or self-hosted via Docker)
- Gmail account with API access enabled
- Apollo.io account (free tier works)
- OpenAI API key

Step 1: Set Up n8n

Cloud (Easiest)

Sign up at n8n.io. Free tier includes 5 active workflows.

Self-hosted (Best for scale)

```
docker run -it --rm \
  --name n8n \
  -p 5678:5678 \
  -v ~/.n8n:/home/node/.n8n \
  docker.n8n.io/n8nio/n8n
```

Access at `http://localhost:5678`.

Step 2: Build Your Prospect Data Source

Apollo.io Setup

1. Sign up at apollo.io
2. Use filters to build your prospect list:
    - Industry, Company size, Geography, Job title

3. Export to CSV (50 free exports/month on free tier)
4. Upload CSV to Google Sheets — this becomes your prospect database

Required columns:

```
first_name | last_name | email | company | title | linkedin_url | status |
last_email_sent | email_count
```

`status` values: `pending`, `email_1_sent`, `email_2_sent`, `email_3_sent`, `replied`, `unsubscribed`

LinkedIn (Alternative)

Use Phantombuster's LinkedIn Profile Scraper to extract prospects, then enrich emails with Hunter.io.

Step 3: Create the Core Outreach Workflow

In n8n, create a new workflow:

Node 1: Schedule Trigger

- Cron: `0 9 * * 1-5` (9am, Monday–Friday)

Node 2: Google Sheets — Read Prospects

- Operation: Read rows
- Filter: status = "pending" AND email_count = 0
- Limit: 20 (don't send too many at once)

Node 3: Loop Over Items

- Loop through each prospect

Node 4: OpenAI — Personalise Email

- Model: gpt-4o-mini (cost-effective)
- Prompt:

```
Write a personalised cold email for this prospect. Keep it under 80 words.
Tone: direct, professional, no waffle.

Prospect:
- Name: {{ $json.first_name }}
- Company: {{ $json.company }}
- Title: {{ $json.title }}

Template to personalise (don't change structure, just make it feel personal):

Subject: Quick question about {{ $json.company }}'s [relevant process]

Hi {{ $json.first_name }},

I noticed [observation about their company/role/industry].

We help [ICP description] automate [pain point] — saving them [specific outcome].

Worth 15 minutes to see if it applies to {{ $json.company }}?

[Your name]
```

Node 5: Gmail — Send Email

- To: `{{ $json.email }}`
- Subject: (from AI output)
- Body: (from AI output)
- Reply-to: your@email.com

Node 6: Google Sheets — Update Status

- Update row where email = `{{ $json.email }}`
- Set: status = "email_1_sent", last_email_sent = today, email_count = 1

Step 4: Build the Follow-Up Sequence

Create a second workflow for follow-ups:

Node 1: Schedule Trigger

- Cron: `0 9 * * 1-5`

Node 2: Google Sheets — Read Follow-up Queue

- Filter: status = "email_1_sent" AND last_email_sent <= 4 days ago

Node 3: OpenAI — Generate Follow-up

- Shorter prompt, reference first email:

```
Write a short follow-up email (under 50 words). Don't be pushy.
Acknowledge they're busy. Add one piece of value (a tip, resource, or insight).
First name: {{ $json.first_name }}, Company: {{ $json.company }}
```

Node 4–6: Same as above (Send + Update status to email_2_sent)

Repeat for email 3 (Day 9 — final break-up email).

Step 5: Reply Detection (Critical)

If someone replies, you must stop all automated follow-ups immediately.

Gmail Trigger Workflow

Create a separate workflow:

1. **Trigger:** Gmail — Watch for new emails
2. **Filter:** From address matches anyone in your prospects sheet
3. **Update Google Sheets:** Set status = "replied"
4. **Notify:** Send Slack/Discord message: "Reply from [name] at [company] — check inbox!"

This ensures no prospect gets a follow-up email after they've responded.

Step 6: Unsubscribe Handling

Add an unsubscribe link to every email:

```
P.S. Not interested? [Click here to unsubscribe](https://yourwebhook.url?email={{
$json.email }})
```

Create a n8n webhook that updates the prospect's status to "unsubscribed" when clicked.

Monitoring and Optimisation

Track these in Google Sheets weekly:

- **Send rate:** How many sent per week
- **Open rate:** Use a tracking pixel or Gmail open tracking
- **Reply rate:** Total replies / total sent

Target benchmarks:

- Open rate: 50–65% (with good subject lines)
- Reply rate: 8–15%
- Positive reply rate: 2–5%

If reply rate is below 5%, rewrite your email copy. If open rate is below 40%, fix your subject lines.

Advanced: LinkedIn Message Integration

For a true multichannel sequence:

1. Email Day 1
2. LinkedIn connection request Day 2 (via Phantombuster)
3. LinkedIn message Day 3 (if connected)
4. Email follow-up Day 5

This dramatically increases reply rates for high-value prospects.

For a pre-built sales outreach agent, visit myaiworkforce.ai/marketplace